



Deepin Desktop: Simple and Quick

The author explores Deepin, a distro that's been around for many years, and comes away surprised at its simplicity and responsiveness.

I came across an article praising the Deepin distribution and announcing that the distro was now available as a desktop environment for Fedora, Ubuntu, etc. I can't recall how long it has been since I tried a new distribution or even a different desktop environment. This is all the more surprising because the speed of data downloads is far better than it used to be, and even the cost of downloading data is very low now.

The reason is familiarity. If the current environment meets our needs, there is little incentive to search for or try out something that makes just a marginal difference. I am very comfortable with KDE Plasma on most systems and LXDE on resource constrained systems.

However, I was intrigued by Deepin. While the distribution itself has its origins in 2004 as Hiweed and was renamed as Linux Deepin in 2009, the desktop environment was released in 2012. It has its origins in China. You can find out more about it on the Deepin wikipedia page.

What intrigued me was whether I would find it beautiful in addition to being functional. If so, what would make it so?

Installation and initial experience

As it is available as a desktop environment on Fedora, installing and getting started was simple.

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$ sudo dnf group install "Deepin Desktop"
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I noticed that the window manager was deepin-kwin, so it was probably a fork of kwin. I was trying it on my slower desktop. The initial login surprised me. The desktop started almost as quickly as LXDE. The responsiveness of the mouse and the desktop was excellent, for the system.

I liked the dock, which reminded me of the Mac we had been introduced to in college a long time ago.

Clicking on the menu icon replaced the desktop with the application icons and a search option that reminded me of Ubuntu. On Ubuntu Unity, a similar dock is on the left

by default, but the difference is that Deepin does not have the top bar for various operational icons and notifications. In the case of Deepin, they are all in the dock. Xfce uses the dock in a similar way.

On first usage, the desktop environment reminded me of various other desktops I have used; but yet, it does not feel like a collection of features picked up and put together. It feels like a unified whole, and the responsiveness on even a very slow system (but with 4GB RAM) was remarkable.

Changing the desktop background

Right-clicking on the desktop offers a menu which includes options to open a terminal, and configure corner settings (more about that a little later), 'Wallpaper and Screensaver', etc.

Selecting the 'Wallpaper and Screensaver' option displays only the desktop background and opens a panel of images at the bottom.

This was the first thing that I found beautiful. The absence of any window open on the desktop removed unnecessary distractions.

It is easy to select any image displayed in the panel and set it as the background. Clicking anywhere above the panel returns you to the normal desktop. There is no *Apply*, *Save*, *Exit*, etc, making it simple and functional.

However, to my surprise and irritation, I could not set the wallpaper to any of my images! I spent quite a lot of time struggling, without success. Then as I was viewing an image, I noticed that right-clicking on an image in Deepin's file manager has the option to set it as a wallpaper. So, it is very easy to use unless you are looking in the wrong places! Ease of use is greatly dependent on your past experience!

There is the option of 'Wallpaper Slideshow', which I tried. While it is fun, it becomes distracting during operations and so I did not use it. The option to change the background every time one logs in does seem appealing. While Deepin has been very easy to use so far, I could not find a way to use my own images. The solution I have found at present is to place the photos in the folder '/usr/share/wallpapers/deepin'.